



Rent an Apartment

Housing market, rental platforms, and tenant rights for expats

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Article 1

Complete Guide to Renting an Apartment in Beijing as a Foreigner (2026)

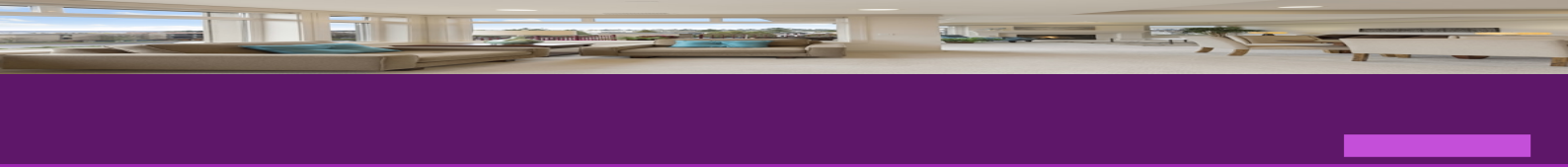
Moving to Beijing and finding the right apartment can feel overwhelming, especially when you don't speak Chinese fluently. This comprehensive guide covers everything you need to know about renting in Beijing as a foreign tenant -- from choosing the right platform to signing your lease.

Step 1: Choose the Right Rental Platform

The Beijing rental market is dominated by several major platforms. Here are the best options for foreigners:

* Ziroom (自如)

* -- China's largest managed apartment platform. Offers fully furnished, standardized



apartments with Wi-Fi, cleaning service, and maintenance included. The app has an English interface option. Best for: young professionals who want a hassle-free experience. Price range: ¥3,000-15,000/month.

* Lianjia (链家)

* -- The most trusted real estate platform in China with verified listings and professional agents. The app is in Chinese, but agents in expat areas often speak English. Best for: families and long-term renters. Commission: typically one month's rent.

* Beike (贝壳找房)

* -- A housing aggregator that pulls listings from multiple agencies including Lianjia. Has the largest database of verified properties. Best for: comparing options across agencies.

* HousingAnywhere

* -- International platform popular for medium-term rentals (1-12 months). Verified landlords, secure payments, and flexible lease terms. Best for: students and short-term

stays.

Step 2: Understand Beijing's Rental Neighborhoods

Beijing is massive -- choosing the right neighborhood is crucial. Here are the most popular areas for foreigners:

- * Chaoyang District (朝阳区)

- * -- The expat hub. Sanlitun, CBD, and Liangmaqiao are popular with young professionals. Rent: ¥5,000-15,000/month for 1BR.

- * Haidian District (海淀区)

- * -- Near major universities (Peking, Tsinghua). Wudaokou is the student hub. Rent: ¥4,000-8,000/month for 1BR.

- * Wangjing (望京)

- * -- Known as "Koreatown" but increasingly popular with all expats. Modern apartments,

great food scene. Rent: ¥4,500-9,000/month for 1BR.

* Shunyi District (顺义)

* -- Where most international schools are located. Villa communities with gardens.

Popular with expat families. Rent: ¥8,000-25,000/month for a villa.

Step 3: Documents You'll Need

* Valid passport with current visa

* Residence permit (临时住宿登记表) -- register at your local police station within 24

hours of moving in

* Proof of income or employment contract (some landlords require this)

* Security deposit: typically 1-2 months' rent (押一付三 = 1 month deposit, 3 months

upfront is standard)

Step 4: The Rental Process

Browse listings on your preferred platform and schedule viewings (看房 kàn fáng)

Visit apartments in person -- never sign without seeing the place first

Negotiate the rent -- in Beijing, it's common to negotiate 5-10% off the listed price

Review the lease contract carefully. Ask for an English translation if needed

Pay the deposit and first month's rent. Get official receipts (收据 shōu jù)

Register at the local police station (派出所 pài chū suǒ) within 24 hours

Step 5: Essential Tips for Foreign Renters

- * Always use a

- * reputable platform

- * -- avoid WeChat-only deals without verification

- * Check water pressure, heating system, and internet speed during viewing
- * In Beijing, central heating (暖气 nuǎn qì) is included in rent from Nov 15 - Mar 15
- * Negotiate who pays for utilities (水电费 shuǐ diàn fèi) -- usually the tenant
- * Get renter's insurance -- available on
- * Zhongmin
- * or through your agent
- * Join expat WeChat groups for your neighborhood for real-time advice

Common Scams to Avoid:

- * Agent asks for deposit before viewing -- SCAM. Never pay before seeing the apartment
- * Price is significantly below market rate -- likely bait-and-switch
- * Landlord refuses to provide 房产证 (property ownership certificate) -- verify ownership
- * No written contract -- always insist on a formal lease agreement



Sources: Sources: [Ziroom](https://www.ziroom.com) • [Lianjia](https://www.lianjia.com) • [Beike](https://www.ke.com)

Beijing Neighborhood Guide: Where Expats Live in

2026

Choosing the right neighborhood in Beijing can make or break your experience as an expat. This guide breaks down the most popular areas where foreigners live, with real rent prices, transport links, and lifestyle tips for each area.

1. Sanlitun (三里屯) -- Chaoyang District

The beating heart of Beijing's expat scene. Sanlitun offers a cosmopolitan lifestyle with international restaurants, bars, shopping malls (Taikoo Li), and the embassy district nearby. Most young professionals and single expats choose this area for its vibrant nightlife and walkability.

* Rent: ¥6,000-12,000/month (1BR apartment)

* Nearest metro: Tuanjiehu (Line 10), Dongsi Shitiao (Line 2)

* Best for: Young professionals, nightlife lovers

* Nearby: Taikoo Li, Nali Patio, The Opposite House, Element Fresh, Great Leap Brewing

2. CBD / Guomao (国贸) -- Chaoyang District

Beijing's Central Business District is where many multinational companies are headquartered. Modern high-rise apartments with stunning city views, premium shopping at China World Mall, and easy access to Line 1 and Line 10. Popular with corporate expats and finance professionals.

* Rent: ¥8,000-20,000/month (1BR luxury apartment)

* Nearest metro: Guomao (Line 1/10), Jintaixizhao (Line 10)

* Best for: Corporate expats, finance professionals

* Nearby: China World Mall, CCTV Headquarters, Kerry Centre

3. Liangmaqiao (亮马桥) -- Chaoyang District

Known as the "embassy area," Liangmaqiao is home to many foreign embassies, international hotels, and upscale restaurants. The area has a more relaxed, residential feel compared to Sanlitun while still being centrally located. Many expat families choose this area for its safety and international community.

* Rent: ¥7,000-15,000/month (1BR apartment)

* Nearest metro: Liangmaqiao (Line 10)

* Best for: Embassy staff, expat families

* Nearby: Lufthansa Center, Kempinski Hotel, Japanese and Korean restaurants

4. Wangjing (望京) -- Chaoyang District

Wangjing has transformed from a quiet residential area into a bustling expat neighborhood, often called Beijing's "Koreatown." It's home to many tech companies



(Alibaba, Meituan offices) and offers excellent Korean and international dining. Modern apartment complexes with good amenities at more affordable prices than central Chaoyang.

* Rent: ¥4,500-9,000/month (1BR apartment)

* Nearest metro: Wangjing (Line 14/15), Wangjing South (Line 14)

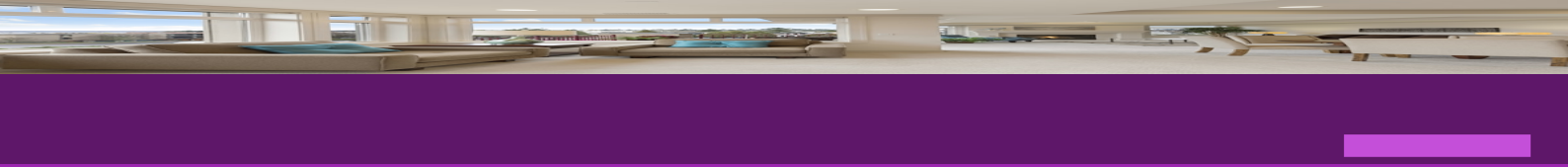
* Best for: Tech workers, Korean food lovers, budget-conscious expats

* Nearby: Wangjing SOHO, Korean restaurants, Wanda Plaza

5. Wudaokou (五道口) -- Haidian District

Known as "宇宙中心" (Center of the Universe) among Chinese students, Wudaokou is the student hub of Beijing. Surrounded by Peking University, Tsinghua University, and Beijing Language and Culture University, it's the most affordable expat-friendly area.

Great for students and young professionals on a budget.



* Rent: ¥3,500-7,000/month (1BR apartment)

* Nearest metro: Wudaokou (Line 13)

* Best for: Students, budget-conscious young professionals

* Nearby: University campuses, Korean and Japanese restaurants, bars, bookstores

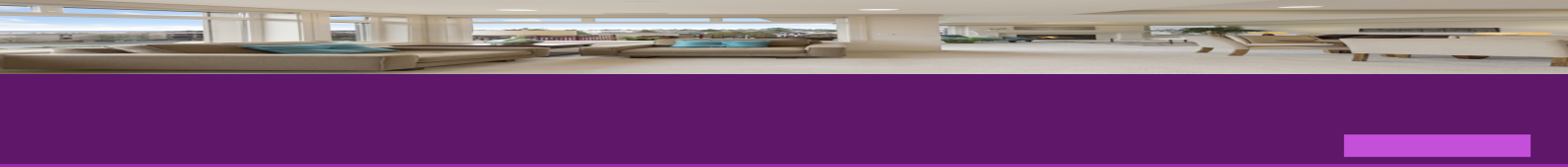
6. Shunyi (顺义) -- International School Belt

Shunyi is where most expat families with school-age children live. Home to major international schools (ISB, WAB, Dulwich), it offers villa communities with gardens, space, and a suburban lifestyle. The trade-off is a longer commute to central Beijing (40-60 minutes).

* Rent: ¥10,000-30,000/month (villa with garden)

* Nearest metro: Shunyi (Line 15), but most residents drive

* Best for: Expat families with children



* Nearby: International schools, Europlaza, Pinnacle Plaza, River Garden

How to Choose Your Neighborhood:

* Budget under ¥5,000/month:

* Wudaokou, Wangjing, or shared apartment in Chaoyang

* Budget ¥5,000-10,000/month:

* Sanlitun, Liangmaqiao, Wangjing (1BR)

* Budget ¥10,000+/month:

* CBD luxury apartments, Shunyi villas

* With kids:

* Shunyi (international schools) or Liangmaqiao (central, safe)

* Near work:

* Use

* Baidu Maps

* to check commute times

Pro Tip:

Before signing a lease, visit the neighborhood at different times -- morning rush hour, evening, and weekend. Check the nearest metro station distance, grocery stores (look for

Womai

or

Hema/盒马

for delivery), and the general vibe. Join the neighborhood's WeChat group to connect with other expats.

Sources: Sources: [Ziroom](https://www.ziroom.com) • [Lianjia](https://www.lianjia.com) • [Beike](https://www.ke.com) • [Beijing Kids](https://www.beijing-kids.com)

How to Find an Apartment in China Using Major

Rental Platforms (Step-by-Step)

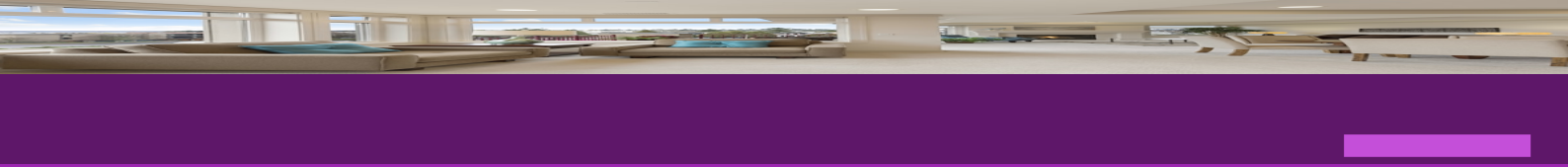
If you're a foreigner moving to China, the smartest approach is to use established rental platforms rather than dealing with individual landlords directly. Major platforms offer verified listings, standardized contracts, English support, and dispute resolution -- things you won't get from a random landlord on WeChat. Here's a detailed walkthrough of how to find your apartment using China's biggest rental platforms.

Why Use Big Platforms Instead of Individual Landlords?

- * Verified listings

- * -- Platforms like

- * Zillow



* and

* Lianjia

* send agents to photograph and verify every apartment. What you see online is what you get.

* Standardized contracts

* -- No surprise clauses. Platform contracts are reviewed by legal teams and follow local regulations.

* Maintenance support

* -- Something breaks? Submit a repair ticket in the app. With an individual landlord, you're calling someone who may not answer.

* Dispute resolution

* -- If there's a problem with your deposit or lease, the platform mediates. With a private landlord, you're on your own.

* English support

* -- Some platforms (especially

* Ziroom

*) have English interfaces. Others have English-speaking agents in expat areas.

Platform 1: Ziroom (自如) -- Best for Furnished Apartments

Ziroom

is China's largest managed apartment platform. Think of it as the "WeWork of apartments" -- everything is standardized, furnished, and move-in ready.

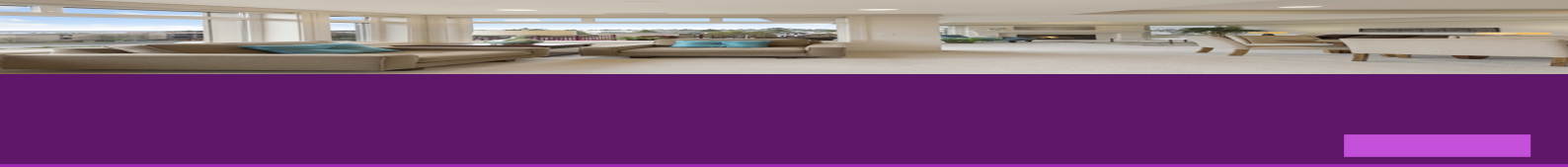
* Website:

* ziroom.com

* (app available on iOS/Android)

* What you get:

* Fully furnished apartment with Wi-Fi, washing machine, refrigerator, air conditioning,



and basic kitchen. Bi-weekly cleaning service included.

* Price range:

* ¥3,000-15,000/month depending on city and room type

* Lease terms:

* 1 year minimum. "Ziroom Free" option allows shorter stays at higher rates.

* How to use:

* Download the app → select your city → browse listings → schedule viewing → sign contract online → move in

* Payment:

* Monthly via app (WeChat Pay/Alipay/bank card). No cash.

* Pros:

* No agent fees, everything is standardized, 24/7 maintenance hotline

* Cons:

* Slightly more expensive than raw market rate, less personal touch

Platform 2: Lianjia (链家) -- Best for Long-Term Rentals

Lianjia

is China's most trusted real estate platform with 200,000+ agents nationwide.

* Website:

* lianjia.com

* Price range:

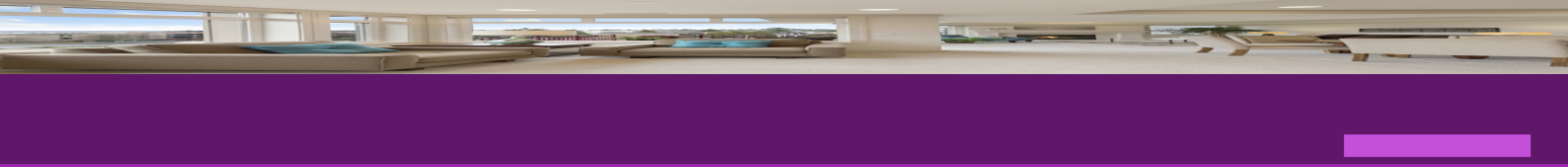
* ¥2,500-20,000/month -- wider range than Zillow

* Agent fee:

* Typically one month's rent

* Pros:

* Huge inventory, professional agents, verified ownership certificates (房产证)



* Cons:

* Agent fee, app is Chinese-only

Platform 3: Beike (贝壳找房) -- Best for Comparing Options

Beike

is the parent company of Lianjia and acts as a housing aggregator. It pulls listings from Lianjia and dozens of other agencies.

* Website:

* ke.com

* Key feature:

* "VR看房" (VR house viewing) -- tour apartments in 3D from your phone

* Pros:

* Largest database, VR tours, transparent pricing history

Red Flags -- Avoid These:

- * Landlord asks for deposit before viewing -- SCAM
- * Price is 30%+ below market rate -- bait-and-switch
- * No written contract -- always insist on one
- * Landlord refuses to show 房产证 -- may not be the real owner

Sources: Sources: [Ziroom](https://www.ziroom.com) • [Lianjia](https://www.lianjia.com) • [Beike](https://www.ke.com)

Article 4

How to Set Up Home WiFi in China: Step-by-Step

Guide (2026)

Unlike some countries where internet is included in the rent, in China you usually need to set up your own home broadband and WiFi. Here's a complete step-by-step guide.

First: Check if your apartment already has internet

Ask your landlord or rental agent -- is there already an active broadband line from a previous tenant? If yes, you may only need a router. If the service is cancelled, start fresh below.

Step 1 -- Choose an ISP

* China Mobile (中国移动)

* --

* 10086

* -- Largest mobile network, broadband quality varies by building.

* China Unicom (中国联通)

* --

* 10010

* -- Good for gaming and international connections.

* China Telecom (中国电信)

* --

* 10000

* -- Traditionally strongest for landline broadband, stable.

Step 2 -- Check availability

Call the hotline and ask: "I want to set up home WiFi. Is your service available in my

building? What plans do you have?" If one ISP says no, try another -- a building may only work with one or two.

Step 3 -- Choose a plan and schedule installation

* Tell the hotline your address and choose a plan: 100 Mbps (streaming/work), 200-500 Mbps (gaming/multiple devices).

* Price: approx. ¥600-¥1500/year. Yearly payment is cheaper.

* The hotline will schedule a time for a technician to visit your apartment.

Step 4 -- Installation day: pay on the spot

The technician comes to your apartment. They bring the modem/router (光猫), set up everything, and you pay them directly on the spot -- no need to visit a service hall

(营业厅). Payment: WeChat, Alipay, or cash. Have your passport ready (they may need to take a photo of it for registration).

Step 5 -- Setup complete

The technician connects the fibre optic port, sets up WiFi, and gives you the SSID and password. You don't need a separate router -- but you can add one later for better range.

Step 6 -- Test and keep info

Make sure all devices connect. Save your broadband account number and technician's contact. Ask for an invoice (发票) if needed.

! Tips for foreigners:

* Hotline and technician rarely speak English -- have a Chinese friend or translation app ready.

* Registration linked to your passport number.

* Most plans are 12 months. Early cancellation may forfeit remaining months.

* Moving? Call ISP to apply for "移机" (moving service) -- small fee may apply.

Useful phrases:

* 我要装宽带 -- Wǒ yào zhuān kuāndài -- I want to install broadband

* 有WiFi吗? -- Yǒu WiFi ma? -- Is there WiFi?

* 我要开发票 -- Wǒ yào kāi fāpiào -- I need an invoice

Sources: Sources: [China Mobile](https://www.10086.cn) • [China Unicom](https://www.10010.com) • [China Telecom](https://www.189.cn)

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Generated on June 9, 2026

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